socialism to anyone that would listen. ‘He talked and talked, and I always had to wait until he stopped,’ Aguirre laughed. ‘He spoke long, nice German sentences and I had to wait until I translated. Sometimes I had to say: stop!’5

Margot kept busy too. She was an avid reader and voracious letter writer. While she loved the South American sunshine, she longed for snow and white forests, a point she later wrote repeatedly from Chile to acquaintances when they ask if she missed Germany: ‘Not Germany, but the German winter.’

Good news arrived by post on 23 March when Honecker was informed he was to receive a pension backdated from August 1992. From then on, funds were transferred monthly to his bank account in Chile.6 Deposits were topped up by occasional donations from political friends which helped pay medical bills and the mortgage. ‘Every monetary gift was welcomed, and at least as a gesture of solidarity,’ Aguirre remembered.7 There were also visitors and gifts from countries and organisations which the GDR had helped and since the country no longer existed, the Honeckers accepted their gratitude.8 On one occasion, Yasser Arafat was asked if he ‘contributed a significant sum’ to Honecker’s oldage pension. ‘I did not give him anything, although I would like to. I am proud that Erich Honecker is my friend. I, personally, and the Palestinian people owe him much. The GDR helped us politically and militarily and trained numerous Palestinian students. I am a man who never forgets such things.’9

A huge ‘contribution’ to the Honecker pension pot came from Cuban singer Silvio Rodriguez, who donated money collected after a concert in Santiago. A hat was even passed around at a luncheon bash in April marking Margot’s 66th birthday at the ‘Rincön de los Teatinos’ restaurant – an occasion used as an official welcome party for Erich. In all, around a hundred guests – including many Chileans and political comrades arrived at what turned out to be Margot and Erich’s last hurrah. There were other reasons to celebrate that month after the Berlin Regional Court shut down the trial against Honecker for good, saying his ‘serious illness’ was justification for the trial’s closure.10